

Year 5 Reading Comprehension - School Garden Debate

Name: _____ Date: _____

ACARA v9.0: AC9E5LY05 - use comprehension strategies to analyse information, ideas and literal and inferred meaning in texts.

Learning Intention

I can compare points of view and identify evidence used to support an argument.

Reading Strategy

Notice who is speaking, what they want and which reasons or evidence support each viewpoint.

Vocabulary Helper

debate: a discussion where different views are presented

proposal: a suggested plan

maintenance: work needed to keep something in good condition

compromise: an agreement where both sides adjust

Before You Read

Think about a time people had different opinions but still needed to make one fair decision.

The School Garden Debate

The Year 5 student council meeting began with a proposal: turn the unused corner near the library into a vegetable garden. Sienna supported the idea immediately. She argued that students could learn science outdoors, grow herbs for the cooking club and make the school grounds more welcoming.

Not everyone agreed. Max pointed out that gardens need regular maintenance. During school holidays, someone would need to water the plants. He also worried that the space might attract insects near the library doors.

Mrs Patel asked the council to list evidence rather than repeat opinions. Sienna showed photos of another local school garden and explained how their roster worked. Max found information about native plants that need less water. Slowly, the debate changed from Should we build it? to How could we build it responsibly?

By the end of the meeting, the council reached a compromise. They would begin with two raised beds, choose hardy plants and invite family volunteers to help during holidays. The decision was stronger because both excitement and concerns were taken seriously.

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Questions and written response

Warm Up

Write the two main viewpoints in the debate: one for the garden and one concern about the garden.

Build Your Skills

1. What does Sienna want the student council to do?

2. What concerns does Max raise?

3. Why does Mrs Patel ask students to list evidence?

4. How does Sienna support her viewpoint?

5. How does Max help improve the final plan even though he has concerns?

6. What compromise does the council reach?

Strong Challenge

Write which viewpoint you find stronger at the start of the debate. Then explain how the final compromise changes the issue.

I Can

- ☐ I read carefully.
- ☐ I used evidence.
- ☐ I explained my thinking.

High Five!

Strong thinking! You compared viewpoints and noticed how evidence improves ideas.

Teacher Feedback

Strength: _____

Next: _____

School Garden Debate - Answer Key

For teachers, parents and tutors

Detailed Answers

1. She wants to turn the unused corner near the library into a vegetable garden.
2. He is concerned about maintenance, holiday watering and insects near library doors.
3. Evidence helps the council make a thoughtful decision instead of repeating opinions.
4. She shows photos of another school garden and explains their roster.
5. His concerns lead to ideas such as hardy plants, less watering and a responsible plan.
6. They agree to start with two raised beds, choose hardy plants and invite family volunteers.

Success Guide

A strong response compares both sides fairly and explains how evidence or compromise changes the decision.

Parent Tip - At Home

At home, have a mini debate about a simple choice, such as screen time or dinner. Each person must give one reason and one piece of evidence.

Teacher Tip - In Class

Assign students to Sienna, Max and Mrs Patel roles. Students identify claims, evidence and compromise before writing answers.

Extension Idea

Create a pros and cons table for another school improvement idea.